



It may be smaller than a grain of salt, but this shell is one of the most beautiful in nature. It is a sphere made from many plates, called coccoliths (ko-koh-liths). Living inside is the organism that built it, a coccolithophore (ko-koh-lith-oh-for) – quite a mouthful to say!

Coccolithophores are miniature life forms that live in the sea. If conditions are right they can increase rapidly. They can fit a whole lifetime into one day, so they multiply very quickly! Coccolithophores gather together in “blooms”, which drift on the surface of the sea. One litre of seawater may contain more than 100 million of them.

The blooms are even visible in satellite images taken from space.

They turn the sea milky-white, because they reflect sunlight.